

Throughout the summer, friends came down from Buenos Aires to stay with us for three days to a week. I was retired, in my own beach house, all summer long with the person I loved most, without having to commute back to a job. I had a freezer full of Argentine beef. Man, that was living.

In March 1985, we returned to Buenos Aires. I started work on my second novel, kept up my sax lessons, and met old business associates for lunch. After lunch they returned to the office. I went to a movie, to a museum, the zoo, or home for a siesta.

In May we went to Spain and visited ten different cities in three months. We became amateur experts in Spanish history and bullfights. We learned to cook paella, beans, and fried fish. After three months in Spain we flew to the United States to visit family and friends. We started in New York and then flew to Los Angeles, San Francisco, Portland, and northern Washington State. In November 1985, after six months abroad, we returned to Argentina. We spent the summer in Punta del Este, across the river in Uruguay.

By March 1986, I was ready to sink my teeth into something more solid. I enrolled in a six-week Skills Development Program at the Berklee College of Music in Boston. The program started on July 7, 1986. Before going to Boston, we spent a month touring the southeastern United States. We soaked up southern hospitality, talked about the Civil War, saw the sights, and checked out inexpensive places to live.

The Berklee course in Boston improved my sax and opened my mind to different kinds of music. After two months there we were ready for another trip, so we flew back to Europe. We wandered through Hungary and Yugoslavia for six weeks. The idea was to see some commies up close. *Time* magazine had just done a cover story on Hungary, affirming that Hungary since 1956 has been the biggest economic success in the Soviet bloc. Budapest is a beautiful city, with well-dressed but sad people. We loved Yugoslavia, especially the clear